

1.1 The First Video Game

The earliest computer games were played on supercomputers. Of course, these were found only in large universities or the laboratories of large corporations or government agencies, such as, the US Department of Defence. Thus, till about mid 1970s, games were restricted from being available to the common populace.

A lot of games claim to be the first video game, and considering the number of formats and genres that exist today, this isn't surprising. If you ask a lay person to name the first PC or video game, the qualifying factor being that there must be some computing involved in the game, one of the most common answers you'd get is *Pac-Man*. This pill-chomping circle was a craze, probably the single largest gaming icon for almost a decade, but for those who came in late, here's a bit of a news flash: *Pac-Man* was released in 1980 by Midway games, almost a decade after the first console game made its debut and a good 30 years after the first ever computer game thrilled the researchers at Cambridge University.

A S Douglas was the name of the scientist, and the game was OXO. If you think you haven't heard of it, think again—we call it “X-es and zeroes”! Douglas developed a graphical version of this game way back in 1952, making it the first ever video game. Developed at Cambridge University to demonstrate a thesis on human-computer interaction, OXO was played on the EDSAC, and used a CRT display. To its credit, OXO is the first known graphical game to have been played on a computer.

Douglas, however, was never credited with being the inventor or father of computer games. That distinction belongs to William Higinbotham. In 1958, he created *Tennis for Two*, a game that used an oscilloscope as a display unit. His exhibit at the Brookhaven National Laboratory in New York looked like a primitive *Pong* and played pretty much along the same lines. It showed a tennis court from the side, and the ball was affected by gravity. The controllers for the game were bulky, and consisted of a knob for the trajec-